

GREY AREA

Desecration of cinematic history? Or a necessary upgrade to attract a younger audience? Purists are aghast at attempts to glamourise Satyajit Ray's masterpiece, *Pather Panchali*, but the advocates of colour are determined to transform poverty's hue.

■ By Swagata Sen

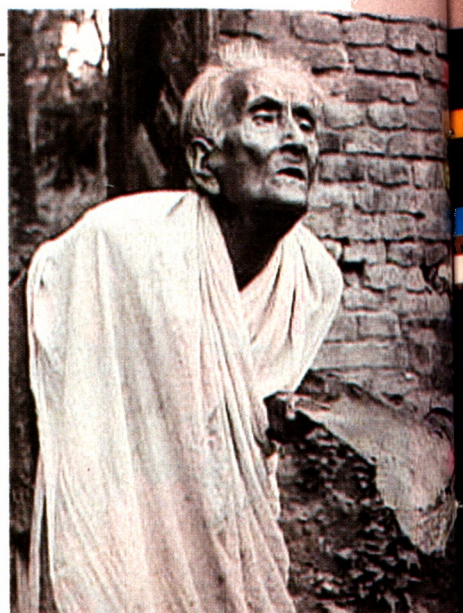
Colour, for Satyajit Ray, often went beyond the literal meaning. He berated the 'colour' added to commercial Hindi films to create a kind of fantastic Neverland that made foreign viewers believe was the real India. He often defended the use of colour when film theorists decided black and white was a better medium for films to be called an art, making India's first colour film, *Kanchanjungha*, as early as 1962, before going back to the other medium for a decade of films. On a film called *Ashani Sanket* that he chose to do in colour, he once quipped that "poverty has its own special colour".

Pather Panchali (Song of the Little Road, 1955), Ray's first film, was internationally regarded as one of the greatest black and white films ever made and won over a dozen awards in film festivals worldwide. The film, based on Bibhutibhusan Bandyopadhyay's novel, depicts the story of a village boy Apu, his sister Durga, his parents and his aunt battling poverty, but finding happiness in life's simple experiences—established Ray as one of Asia's greatest filmmakers. Poverty's special colour in the film has mesmerised audiences and film critics alike, and for the last 52 years, has been standing its ground in various shades of grey. Now, Sankranti

Creations, a Mumbai-based company, has started a project, triggering protests among Ray enthusiasts—that of adding colour to this classic.

Sandip Ray, the late maestro's son and a well-known director himself, doesn't mince words when he calls the project "atrocious". "Baba never regretted making *Pather Panchali* in black and white," he says, adding, "he never said given the opportunity, he would like to turn the film into a colour movie." Not having the copy-right, he will not be able to stop the project. A section of Bengal's serious filmmakers, such as Mrinal Sen, Buddhadeb Dasgupta and Goutam Ghose have also been quite vocal against what they term as "desecration". Recently, a Bengali television channel conducted a poll on whether people would like to watch the film in colour. About 96 per cent said "no".

The Kolkata-based Ray Society is the sole custodian of most of the filmmaker's works, and of their preservation and restoration. Arup Kumar De, its CEO, is aghast. In Ray's 1972 Bengali article *Rongeen Chhobi* (Coloured Images), the maestro writes, "A few years ago, those who were closely associated with cinema believed that a serious subject and colour didn't go together. Nobody abroad holds such a view any longer; but in our country, people who have seen only Hindi films, or



aren't familiar with the restrained use of colour in serious foreign films, are likely to harbour such ideas."

Clearly, Ray was not averse to using colour—16 of his 36 films were in colour—even in serious films dealing with non-glamorous subjects. Why then, does he object to the colouring initiative? "Ray's comments on the use of colour, do not give anyone—neither Sankranti Creations nor the West Bengal Government—the moral licence to reproduce *Pather Panchali* in colour." Ray had finished his article with a warning: "The horrible effects that can be produced by an intemperate use of colour can be seen in any Hindi film made today. Colour is used purely for glamour. Glossy and multi-hued packaging is necessary to hide the weaknesses of the basic subject."

But in the debate between the literal and the metaphorical, what seems to matter today, as Ray pointed to, is commercial viability. When Ray made *Pather Panchali*, he was an illustrator with an ad agency D.J. Keymer, and ended up selling his records and



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SANDIP RAY, DIRECTOR AND SON OF SATYAJIT RAY